Camp for young artisans

MADRAS

The wide, open Besant camping grounds had some interesting visitors from September 24 to 30. Young artisans they were (ages 13-16) from the southern States of Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Kerala and Tamil Nadu and the Union Territory of Pondicherry.

Binding them together under the canopy of a wide blue sky interspersed with swaying branches of age old trees, was the Crafts Council of India, which sought to provide the young ones an environment of interaction and exposure.

Emphasis was on the 31-odd boys having a memorable time. And that did not mean all fun and games. The accent was on visits to places which would be of professional interest to the young craftsmen such as the VTI — where they could gauge for themselves at what price an article could sell; Mahabalipuram where stone cutters chisel away at granite slabs to fashion out various sculptures; the Airport an example of modern architecture, etc. Evenings were reserved for communication games conducted by a group of educators from different parts of the country.

On September 29 was an open house where the children demonstrated their skill at wood carving, bell metal, sandal wood carving and soft stone carving. Many school children were invited to watch and interact with the child artisans. One must however keep in mind that the youngsters are still in the process of learning the art and hence most of the creations were not very refined.

The children under the Apprenticeship Training Scheme run by the Development Commissioner (Handicrafts) learn craft skills from master craftsmen's. While some come from craftsmens' families, quite a few of them are school dropouts. These children are paid a stipend of Rs. 100 a month during their training period.

Already two such non-formal education camps have been conducted by the Crafts Council of India, and this was the third one. That the camp period was enjoyed immensely by the boys who otherwise work 14 to 15 hours a day and hardly get any time for other activities, was evident from their beaming faces and their unanimous opinion that they would "love to come back again".

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